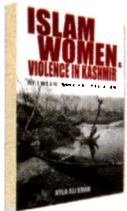


Blood and TEARS

A feminist homage to the brave women who have struggled for a secular Valley since Independence

| By Amitabh Mattoo |



ISLAM, WOMEN & VIOLENCE IN KASHMIR: BETWEEN INDIA AND PAKISTAN
by NYLA ALI KHAN
Tulika
Price: Rs 395
Pages: 185

A new generation of Kashmiris who underwent their rites of passage during the last two decades of violent conflict are now speaking out. From the columns of *Greater Kashmir*, the Valley's largest English daily, to Basharat Peer's powerful memoir *Curfewed Night*, we were witnessing an extraordinary intellectual churning that demands attention. Inevitably soaked in blood and tears, the narratives of these young men and women are challenging the dominant discourse and orthodoxies that have caged Kashmir. Nyla Ali Khan, who teaches at the University of Nebraska-Kearney, USA, is the granddaughter of Sheikh Abdullah, unarguably one of the most popular Kashmiri leaders of the 20th century. A cousin of Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, Khan was schooled in Kashmir and is the daughter of the genteel Suraiya Ali. The only academic amongst Sheikh's children, it is Ali's intellectual genes that have been passed on to Khan rather than the more dominant political DNA of the rest of the Abdullahs.

In this book, Khan analyses the cultural and religious roots of Kashmir's history with particular attention to events during the post-1947 decades and how they have impacted the lives of women. What sets it apart from the innumerable books written on Kashmir during the period of insurgency is the woman's perspective she brings to her study. Khan uses the analytical tools of post-modern, feminist criticism to understand and highlight the role—passive and active—that women have played in Kashmir's history, ranging from the 14th century Lal Ded, a mystic poet who laid the foundations of Kashmir's syncretic culture, to the present day Parveena Ahangar who represents the Association of the Parents of the Disappeared People. In between are oral histories of women who were part of the Women's Defence Corps set up in 1947 after the Pakistan-backed tribal invasion of Kashmir. The bravery of these women who were ready to fight for Kashmir's integrity as a secular space has been largely ignored in all discourses on Kashmir so far and it is for the first time that their stories have been given the credit they deserve. ■



Sikh Chic

Inspector Singh returns to unravel a terror plot

| By Dilip Bobb |

There's a new phrase making the rounds these days: Sikhchic. Adding heft to Sardar cool is Inspector Singh, the fictional Singapore policeman. We first met this jaded, cynical, portly, badly-dressed, beer-swilling, hen-pecked cop in Shamini Flint's first novel set in Malaysia. This is the follow-up novel with Bali as the backdrop.

The author has created a character that is flawed and yet extremely believable. Bali is rocked by a suicide bomb outside the popular Sari Club. Sounds factual enough and Singh's presence is part of an influx of police personnel from the region. He is no terror expert; regular crime is his beat. Among the dead bodies is one with a bullet hole, a murder sought to be concealed in a terror strike. Singh gets his case and an assistant, an Australian policewoman.

The plot revolves around how the two characters interact and eventually stumble across another Islamic terror plot. Singh is that rare fictional character who endears himself to the reader, even though he often comes across as an Asian Inspector Clouseau. What the author cleverly does is to combine an

appealing character, despite his drawbacks, with authentic travelogue and crime, a compelling combination. Singh's love for food and spices allows the author to add additional local flavour in the form of culinary diversions—Indonesian in this case—to the plot, making it a satisfying literary buffet. ■



INSPECTOR SINGH INVESTIGATES: A BALI CONSPIRACY MOST FOUL
by SHAMINI FLINT
Hachette India
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 292